Let me be clear about this: soon after its creation, Israel, consciously or not, became a racist society. For all of us Ashkenazim, it was obvious that the newcomers from North Africa were somehow inferior types, not officially of course, not legally— we were not South Africa—but implicitly, practically.

We were not only almost unconscious of our racism toward the immigrants from North Africa, but totally oblivious of the existence among us of a small Arab minority living on the margins of the State, at its eastern border, and subjected to military administration by Ben-Gurion's socialist government.

At that time, I was working as Nahum Goldmann's political secretary. Goldmann was the president of the World Jewish Congress and the World Zionist Organization. Politically, he was on the center-left and helped finance various left-wing organizations and publications, such as Simha Flapan's *New Outlook*. He decided to make a trip to some of the Arab villages and visit some of the mayors to learn more about the situation. We were warmly received by one mayor, about whom I remember: but what submissiveness, what humiliation! On one side of the mayor's desk was a large photograph of Ben-Gurion; on the other side, a large photograph … of the founder of Zionism: Theodor Herzl.

The Israeli demographic majority shifted over time from the Ashkenazim to the Sephardim or Mizrahim (easterners, meaning Middle-Easterners), but the latter's social status did not change drastically. What changed was their political representation when, in 1977, the right-wing Menachem Begin and his Likud party won the elections. Begin had vociferously adopted the Mizrahim, while he himself was a Polish Jew and most of the members of his government remained Ashkenazim. But the Mizrahim felt that Begin had restored their dignity and they voted heavily for him. A few years later, in 1984, the Sephardi Chief Rabbi, Ovadia Yosef, founded the party that was to represent this Mizrahi electorate: "Shas"